THE MENTAL HEALTH COLLECTIVE

As India's mental health needs surge, a new alliance is highlighting that coordination, and not launching more isolated programmes, is the missing link

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India's mental health crisis is most acutely experienced in moments of uncertainty—where to seek help, how to judge quality and whom to trust in a fragmented system. These questions became personal for Vasvi Bharat Ram, joint vice chairperson of The Shri Ram Schools, when her daughter began struggling with her mental health. "I was forced to confront a reality I had never fully understood," she recalls.

Although her family eventually accessed care, the experience sharpened her awareness of inequity within the system. India continues to face an alarming mental health treatment gap—the share of people who need care but do not receive it is estimated at over 95 per cent. The gap has grown more acute in the post-COVID years, particularly among children and young adults. "Mental health is not a niche issue; it cuts across education, livelihoods, gender, poverty, productivity and overall wellbeing," says Vasvi. "With every fourth person in the country impacted, this is a core development issue."

That understanding shaped the founding of the India Mental Health Alliance (IMHA) in 2023. Rather than pursuing siloed programmes, the alliance was conceived as a systems-level intervention. A cross-sector platform, it brought together service providers, researchers, philanthropists, policymakers and, most importantly, people with lived experience of mental illness. In its first year itself, it grew to include 250 member organisations across 30-plus states and Union territories, making it India's largest mental health coalition.

"India's mental health work is vast and community-rooted, yet often invisible, while philanthropists lack clear pathways to invest for impact. As awareness and prevalence rise, the challenge is scale—across prevention, intervention and postvention," notes Dr Kavita Arora, a child and adolescent psychiatrist, who is the co-founder of Children First and part of the IMHA founding cohort. So the alliance works on curating shared knowledge, strengthening organisational and practitioner capacity, and enabling collaboration rather than duplication. A flagship initiative is its open-source online Knowledge Centre, aimed at making mental healthcare more navigable for families, practitioners and frontline workers.